



SMOOTH TAKEOFF

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

Travellers arriving in Hyderabad by air for the first time cannot be faulted for assuming they will be landing at an airport which will be no different from any of the other Indian airports—crowded, chaotic and badly maintained. However, from next month, any such assumptions would prove wrong as on March 16, the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA)—a prestigious Rs 2,478-crore airport project by GMR Hyderabad International Airport Limited (GHIAL) at Shamshabad in the southern suburbs of the city—will be thrown open to traffic.

It is a landmark not just for Hyderabad but for the entire civil aviation industry as building airports is a difficult task at the best of times and

FLYING START: Departure lounge of the new Hyderabad airport (top); Rao at the construction site

The new international airport at Hyderabad, built in public-private collaboration to match international standards sets a new benchmark for the rest of the country

providing quality is a challenging task. On August 22, 2005, the project achieved financial closure and from then it was to be completed within 36 months. Last fortnight, as he watched two test flights touch the swank new airport, Union Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel could barely hide his joy. "This is India's first truly world-class airport," he gushed.

A collaboration between GMR Infra-structure Limited (GIL) and Malaysia Airport Holdings Berhad (MAHB), the airport promises to be a success story. MAHB's airport in Kuala Lumpur is internationally acknowledged to be one of the best in its customer service. Though the capacity and traffic estimates of the airport is has kept increasing steadily, due to which

